At ISRO, documentation of meetings was considered a clerical job, and it got done in a haphazard manner. Notes are taken randomly, and someone would put it together with deviations from what was originally spoken at the meeting, and the official signed minutes would be ready weeks later, only to be stashed away in cupboards to gather dust. At RCD, minutes were meticulously recorded, as and when people speak. At the end of a meeting, the minutes are read, signed, distributed to the participants, and stored for reference.

Probably the biggest takeaway for me from RCD was the way the quality control team coordinated with the development team. At ISRO, the two teams are often at loggerheads. I hated the quality control guys, I saw them as people always eager to throw a spanner in the wheel. Now, I realised that I should respect them. But back in India, when I was in a hurry to bring liquid technology, there were enough instances when I thought quality control head M C Mathur was unnecessarily creating hurdles for me. There were already seniors, including solid propulsion proponents Kurup and Gowarikar, refusing to see reason in liquid, and Mathur's quality control team made it worse.

My struggle to test and fly the three-tonne engine, which we developed on the lines of SAM7, a surface-to-air missile Russia had given India, added to my hatred for the quality control team. First they didn't allow me to test the engine in Trivandrum, saying it was unsafe. Then, after the first ground test failed, leading to my resignation that Dhawan never allowed, the first flight of the three-tonne engine failed in 1973. An analysis showed that it was due to combined beating and vortex, some complex fluid behavior. But more than analysing the failure and speeding up correction, Mathur kept harping on 'I told you so'.

I remember standing by a blackboard, with a chalk in hand, explaining things to a senior-level meeting when Mathur said this again. I flung the chalk in no specific direction and shouted, 'Mathur if you know how to do it, do the damn thing.'

Mathur was composed. 'Why are you getting agitated, Nambi,' he said. 'It's my job to question and clarify.'